territory". He planned to open five campaign offices in Israel (two of them in settlements), something no candidate had done before.

Israel doesn't have any votes in the Electoral College, nor does it have a large population of American expats. Tzvika Brot, the director of the campaign team, estimated that 300,000 Israeli citizens were eligible to vote in the US election, though non-partisan surveys put the figure closer to 200,000. Either way, they were a tiny fraction of the 136 million Americans who voted. If Israel were a state, it would be smaller than Rhode Island. But the campaign believed they could play a useful role. A 2012 exit poll found that 10 per cent of American Israeli voters were registered in the key swing state of Florida, for example, where Trump ultimately won by less than 113,000 votes.

The American Jews living in Israel, unlike their counterparts back home, are a reliably Republican voting bloc. John McCain won just 21 per cent of the US Jewish vote in 2008, according to exit polls, and Mitt Romney picked up only 30 per cent in 2012. Trump was polling worse than either of them. His brand of white nationalism and his flirtations with anti-Semites earned him few Jewish admirers.

In Israel, however, exit polls found that 85 per cent of 2012 voters opted for Romney, and just 14 per cent for President Obama. McCain won by a similarly lopsided margin. Trump's aides hoped that his embrace of Israel, and his pledge to tear up the nuclear accord with Iran, would add some votes to his column. The campaign offices were shambolic. They hung red-white-and-blue posters across the country, and offered some help on obtaining absentee ballots, but mostly they were a symbol, a low-cost way for Trump to affirm his pro-Israel bona fides.

In the end he only won 49 per cent of the Israeli vote, against 44 per cent for Hillary Clinton, according to exit polls. Turnout was also down sharply compared to the previous two elections. Still, for a historically unpopular candidate like Trump, it counted as a victory. His share of the Jewish vote was twice as large in Israel than in the United States.

During the campaign, he promised to be Israel's "best friend" in Washington, and gave regular interviews to *Israel HaYom*, the Sheldon Adelson-owned newspaper that serves as a mouthpiece for Netanyahu. His rhetoric created meteoric expectations on the Israeli right: one ultra-Orthodox lawmaker went as far as to say that his election heralded the coming of the Messiah. So did his earliest moves, particularly his choice of